



Light on truth

No government intent on working for the people should fear transparency

Protests by political parties and transparency activists have derailed the surreptitious rollout, in Tamil Nadu, of a regressive decision to exempt the Public (Law and Order) Department from the purview of the Right to Information Act, 2005. On September 21, the State government issued a Government Order (G.O.) exercising powers under Section 24 (4) of the RTI Act to notify the department as an “intelligence and security organisation” to which the provisions of the Act shall not apply. While the G.O. surfaced in the public domain only on September 27, strikingly, the Public Department’s designated authorities under the RTI Act had instantly begun citing it to deny information to applicants as early as September 22. This betrayed a system that is shy of investing in transparency. Unsurprisingly, State Law Minister C.T.R. Nirmalkumar was initially defensive about the government’s unilateral decision, which, in any case, required the State to have it placed before the legislature (Section 24 (5), RTI Act). He claimed that the ambit of the exemption was not sweeping enough to shield the entire department, but was intended to prevent the sharing of sensitive information relating to district-level inquiries into incidents of communal clashes and the like. However, shortly thereafter, he announced the G.O.’s withdrawal, without explaining why.

While the State’s afterthought is welcome, the episode has again exposed the political class’s penchant for maintaining secrecy in administrative affairs. Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, whose promise of change came as a breath of fresh air, should have known better. It is concerning that the establishment desired to insulate itself from transparency by amending an Act which, in any case, emphatically enables non-disclosure of information through a long list of exemptions under Section 8. Even otherwise, designated information officers of central/State institutions have displayed an uncanny skill in being economical with the truth, delaying responses or bouncing off queries from RTI Act applicants, citing vague reasons. Besides, concerns about the Digital Personal Data Protection Act diluting the RTI Act further have been widely articulated. It is worrying that the Satrak Nagrik Sangathan’s 2024-25 report card on Information Commissions found a backlog of over 41,000 appeals and complaints before the Tamil Nadu State Information Commission (TNSIC), as of June last year. Yet, the TNSIC is functioning with only half of its sanctioned eight Information Commissioners and has no Chief Information Commissioner. Instead of seeking to defeat the intent of a piece of legislation enacted to empower citizens with access to information, the Tamil Nadu government would do well to strengthen the TNSIC. After all, only an administration that does not fear transparency can be the true harbinger of change.

Waves of rain

Odisha must prepare for repeated bouts of intense downpour

Odisha is experiencing one of its most intense monsoons, recording 1,453 mm of rainfall between June and September 25 this year, a 29% excess. The reason is the unusually large number of atmospheric systems, including 11 over the Bay of Bengal, the latest making landfall near Kalingapatnam on September 23. The IMD had forecast that India would receive 90% of the long-period average partly because an El Niño was expected to develop; the State had finished June itself with a 47% deficit. However, rainfall in the region came to be dominated by the weather systems, which also repeatedly delivered rain without giving locals time to recover. By the State’s estimates, 5.2 lakh people had been affected by July 30 and another 13.5 lakh by August 27. At least 60 locations have so far received more than 100 mm of rain in 24 hours, with the runoff swelling multiple rivers and threatening more floods downstream, including in Bhadrak and Jajpur, and landslides in hilly areas. When a previous bout of rain has already saturated the soil and topped local storage, a new bout could lead more immediately to runoff. While the State’s south is predominantly highland and confronts slope failure risks, its coast is a depositional plain of multiple deltas, rendering a terrain with low gradient through which water does not readily drain into the sea.

The efficacy of the State’s long-standing policy to have zero casualties remains to be seen, especially given the extent to which the ongoing season will stress the drain design and maintenance deficiencies that the CAG had flagged in 2024. Other important data include the eventual crop and infrastructure damage assessments and the peak levels of the Baitarani, Budhabalanga, Jalka, and Rushikulya rivers after the 11th system fades. A study in May by the Odisha University of Agriculture and Technology, based on data from 1901-2020, reported that both maximum one-day and five-day rainfall bursts were becoming more common even as the frequency of heavy-rain days was dipping. The State has been renowned for its disaster management protocols. However, the recurrent waterlogging in urban hubs such as Berhampur and the disruption of inter-State highways and rail networks suggest that its evacuation protocols outpace its civic engineering, with significant room to improve socio-economic and infrastructural resilience. Climate change is also increasingly correlated with more protracted monsoon withdrawal and intense rain events. Taken together, Odisha needs to pivot from anticipating isolated seasonal anomalies to preparing for repeated intense downpours.

It may be tempting to see the recent jerky resumption of negotiations between the Islamic Republic of Iran (IRI) and the United States as *déjà vu*. Similar attempts resulted in the June 17 Memorandum that unravelled within weeks, and the two belligerents resumed their respective blockades of the Strait of Hormuz and Iranian ports.

A different moment now

So, what is different this time? They have both realised that time is not on their side. Their respective domestic considerations make continuation of the seven-month-old war costly and unsustainable. In the short run, going by the past pattern, September 26 saw United States President Trump’s dismissal of Iran’s seven-point proposal, which may be an opening gambit seeking better terms and sequencing. While the Iranian initiative may betray their economic desperation, it also showcases their reasonableness to the Trump sceptics in America and the region who regard his “War of Choice” against Iran as ill-begotten.

The November 3 mid-term congressional elections could upend Mr. Trump as a lame duck. Iranian hardliners, too, need to exhaust this option to justify their aggressiveness. In the longer run, Mr. Trump needs to salvage his legacy to match his extravagant promises. Similarly, the Iranian theocrats need to keep Gen Z engaged and avoid regional blowback from the coagulating mistrust. Thus, while retaining their braggadocio about final victory, each needs to move away from its maximalist obduracy and seek a “Hudna” or temporary peace. The impact of the unfolding imbroglio on the two belligerents as well as on Israel and Gulf states must be examined.

Statistically, the U.S. has a quantitative premium and staying power *vis-à-vis* Iran: It has three times the population, 85 times the GDP and 20 times the military budget. Iran is also at a disadvantage in quality and modernity of weaponry, although its asymmetric strategy has blunted that edge. Washington has weaponised ‘Operation Economic Outcast’ against the already “maximum sanctioned” Iranian economy. Yet, the IRI has not “capitulated”, and the U.S. itself faces inflation, ammunition depletion and isolation. Battle asymmetry aside, their respective combat histories are relevant. The Iran war has been an outlier from the usual U.S. military doctrine of battle dominance through “shock-and-awe”, tech superiority, and leveraging its global primacy through the global politico-financial architecture. The last battle that the U.S. fought as an underdog was its war of independence nearly 250 years ago, and hubris haunts it now. In contrast, Iranians have often been the underdogs to Greeks, Byzantines, Arabs and Ottomans. More recently, British and American manipulation for oil, and Iraq’s 1980 invasion of a fledgling IRI, still frame Iranian



Mahesh Sachdev

Retired Indian Ambassador, specialising in West Asian and oil issues

Both Tehran and Washington must hear the bells toll as mistrust grows and global economies falter

political discourse. Their Shia sect being a minority among the Sunni Muslims reinforces their sense of virtues in suffering and martyrdom. The legacy has made the IRI more determined to face enemies with grit, guile and gumption.

The political ecosystem in Iran is hardened, with dissent stifled and externalised to demonised America and Israel as the two Satans. Mr. Trump has been less successful in getting Americans and the allies abroad behind his trenchant anti-Iran rhetoric. This is partly due to his divisiveness, lack of coherent endgame strategy and inability to protect his allies’ security and economy. Triggering a decapitating war that ignored Iranian politico-military resilience and retaliatory capacity was a strategic blunder. It risked the closure of the two vital maritime choke points, rising hydrocarbon prices, and threatened to push American “hyperpower” into a forever conflict against a middle-ranked, but determined, Iran. Similarly, his recent strategy of inflicting economic pain on Iranians may also fail by making them rally around the flag. Occasional tanker attacks and the ongoing Yemen-Saudi scrimmage notwithstanding, seven months on, the two belligerents are currently licking their wounds.

Uncertain path ahead

Two formidable unknowns loom before some educated projections can be made about the U.S.-Iran conundrum. First, although the Iranian seven-point proposal is based on the June 17 Islamabad memorandum, its precise contents are foggy. Second, the failure of the Islamabad memorandum, subsequent tit-for-tat attacks, the U.S. blockade, Operation Economic Outcast and fire-eating rhetoric since June 17 have deepened mutual mistrust, raising the bar for the *modus vivendi* required for a peace deal. These negatives are balanced by awareness that the continued stalemate would lead to a shared perdition of a hostile Congress blockading Mr. Trump and anti-establishment demonstrations pulling the rug under the Mullahs.

Under a positive scenario, both sides can breathe easier and develop greater mutual empathy. Failure of the June 17 Grand Bargain would have presumably made them more realistic and incremental. So, instead of a race to the bottom, each would need to reluctantly adopt a “Live and Let Live” approach. Despite Mr. Trump’s rejection, signs, such as the Iranian leaders extending their stay in New York, Tehran’s flexibility about controlling the Strait of Hormuz and the use of Qatari mediation instead of alacritous Pakistani generals, seem tentatively positive. To be effective and beneficial to both sides, the deal would have to last at least till November 3, the election date.

Even if this band-aid deal allows the two belligerents to staunch the haemorrhage temporarily, what guarantees its long-term sequel, say, after the Congressional elections? The

Tackling food loss and waste — India’s opportunity



Konda Reddy Chavva

Officer-in-Charge, FAO Representation in India

Cutting food losses can strengthen food security, conserve resources and advance climate goals

across India’s agrifood systems to translate the triple win from theme to practice. Generating evidence, testing technologies and mobilising investment from farm to market to the city have been the core of these initiatives.

When food is lost, so are the resources used to produce it. Reducing losses can help India meet its climate and resource-efficiency goals while strengthening food security. The scope for reducing losses is greatest with better storage, drying, cooling, moisture management and processing. Digital tools such as traceability systems can further improve how food is moved and managed through the supply chain.

Food loss and waste need to be integrated more systematically into agricultural planning, food-processing strategies, climate action and investment decisions. This means directing finance towards technologies and infrastructure where they can have the greatest impact, while ensuring that solutions remain affordable and accessible to farmers, producer organisations and small businesses. Circular approaches can add another dimension. Surplus food can be redistributed, while unavoidable organic residues can be converted into compost, biogas or energy, reducing waste and creating additional economic value.

Wholesale markets, overlooked opportunity

Assessments by the FAO and the National Council of Agriculture Marketing Boards (COSAMB) have found that major wholesale markets can generate up to 100 tonnes of organic waste a day; in some cities as much as a fifth of all urban organic waste reaches landfills. Nationally, this adds up to an estimated 3.5 million tonnes a year. It is no waste stream but a resource base, which if treated, can

IRI and the U.S. are certain to use the interregnum to “recharge their batteries” and get ready for the next round. Their mutual scepticism and contentious issues such as the nuclear and missile programmes, and the proxy non-state actors could impede any progress towards permanent normalisation. A “high noon” can be expected by mid-November.

The sequel would depend on which of the two belligerents is able to hold his flock together. An inherently unpredictable Mr. Trump may only suspend the gamut of anti-Iran measures and keep his forces deployed in the region. Similarly, Iran is unlikely to let go of control of the Strait of Hormuz as future deterrence. To dissuade him from resuming military kinetics, Iran has already unveiled its possible escalatory ladder that includes advanced weaponry, a possible al-Houthi blockade of Bab al-Mandeb, retaliatory attacks on America’s Gulf allies and hints of pre-emptive strikes. Simultaneously, Tehran has sought a regional diplomatic reset through an interim supervisory arrangement with Oman on the Strait of Hormuz, to be endorsed by other Gulf littoral states.

Wider regional consequences

The past two years have brought Israel and Iran into two direct no-holds-barred wars. Intense drone and missile attacks have convinced Israeli public opinion that Iran constitutes an existential threat. On its part, Iran is unlikely to forgive the Lesser Satan for the assassination of its last Supreme Leader. Their resultant intense regional geopolitical competition, particularly in the Levant, would outlast any Tehran-Washington peace deal, giving their two-millennia-old civilisational animus a new edge. Although the October 27 Knesset elections may see hawkish anti-Iran Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu replaced, any successor is likely to be hostile to an Iran pursuing a nuclear duality. Iran can be expected to rely on its proxies and asymmetric arsenal to create a balance of power with Israel equipped with state-of-the-art U.S. weapons. In the long run, time would favour the one with better innovative skills. While Israel is a “Startup Nation”, Iran has also been impressively inventive under pressure.

Other regional countries in the Arabian Peninsula, Iraq and Jordan, were caught in the crossfire and suffered considerable collateral damage under Iranian retaliation. Their hydrocarbon exports and other economic activities have been stifled. In most cases, their extensive forex reserves are likely to help them tide over the turbulence. However, their long-standing security reliance on the U.S. would call for a thorough reappraisal. Among the uncertainties they need to tackle is the future of oil, now more tightly tied to geopolitics than the supply-demand equilibrium.

In this war, “time” has emerged as an element even more slippery and opaque than oil.

offset roughly 3.3 million tonnes of CO₂-equivalent emissions annually, or close to \$30 million in carbon credits.

A 50-tonne-a-day bio-CNG plant in Surat, Gujarat, has been run through a private-sector partnership for over five years and reportedly cuts methane-related emissions by about 7,500 tonnes a year.

India can adapt such models to local conditions, including the commodity mix and infrastructure of different markets. Municipalities and market committees can also improve organic-waste segregation, collection and treatment, while developing markets for compost, biogas and other recovered materials.

Investment and innovation

India must move from individual interventions to a more connected national approach with financing at its core. The FAO and the Small Industries Development Bank of India (SIDBI) are linking identified food-loss hotspots with climate-resilient technologies such as drying, moisture control, energy-efficient cooling and storage, while SIDBI is arranging finance to help small and medium enterprises adopt them.

The FAO is also working to equip Indian cities with a practical “Package of Practices” for urban food loss and waste management, giving municipalities the tools to measure, prevent, reduce, redistribute and valorise waste across households, wholesale markets, retail and food service.

India now has the data, technology and viable models to reduce food loss and waste. The priority is to close data gaps, direct investment and make loss reduction part of agricultural, food-processing, urban and climate policy.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Institutions face pressure

There is now a widespread public perception across the country that India’s democracy is facing pressures — institutions such as the Election Commission of India, the judiciary, the Enforcement Directorate, the Central Bureau of Investigation and the IAS and IPS machinery seem to be struggling to discharge their constitutional duties sincerely, for reasons best

known to them. The way the selection process for the Chief Election Commissioner has been diluted to have a pliant person in the chair has, obviously, paved the way for the botched operation of the Special Intensive Revision, which seems intended to manipulate electoral outcomes to the advantage of a political group. Indian citizens can no longer afford to be mute spectators to the growing

tendency of constitutional functionaries to seek the goodwill of their political bosses rather than remain loyal to the country. And, of course, fearless and meaningful journalism is expected of the Indian media, whose image badly needs to be restored.

Ravindrababu,
Hyderabad

Banking sector issues

The deferment of the proposed three-day bank

strike by the bank unions following discussions with bank managements is a welcome step. A five-day working week was agreed upon in the last settlement two and a half years ago, but it is yet to be implemented. The unions have also expressed deep concern over the lack of unilateral implementation. The IBA should come forward and resolve all outstanding issues expeditiously, considering

the importance of the banking sector to the nation’s economy.
J. Anantha Padmanabhan,
Tiruchi, Tamil Nadu

Justice delayed

The ‘Data Point’ (Opinion page, September 28), on pendencies in cases of assault, was an eye-opener on the issue of women’s safety. Women in India are often revered as mothers and goddesses, yet remain vulnerable to gender-based

inequalities. While women are being empowered on the one hand, the continuing crimes against them on the other are deeply disturbing. The judiciary needs to work on a war footing to ensure that cases involving crimes against women are not delayed.

Balasubramaniam Pavani,
Secunderabad

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.